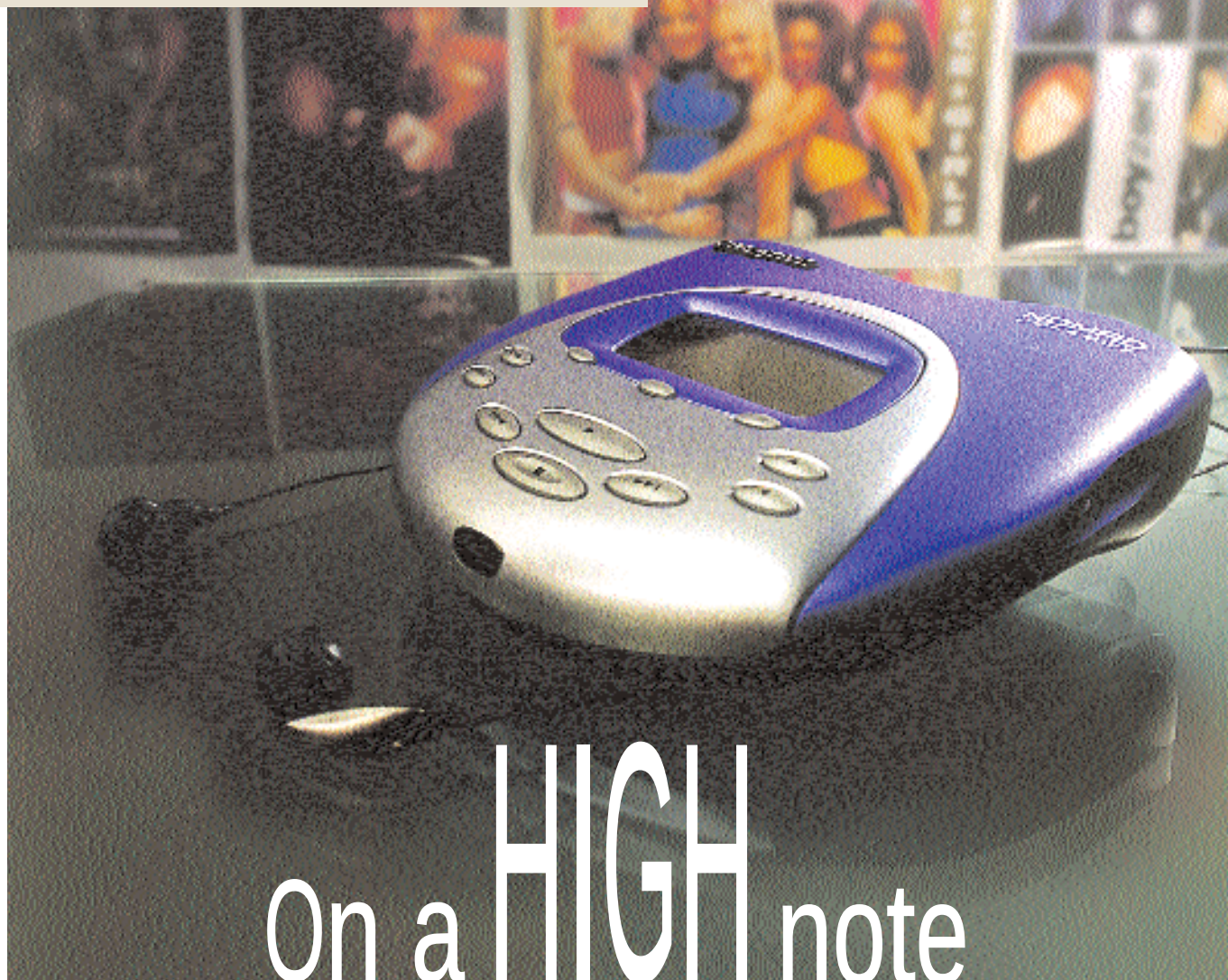


IN TEST: 8 MP3 PLAYERS



On a HIGH note

There's no stopping this tune now! No matter how many RIAs sue Napster, MP3s and MP3 players are here to stay

VARUN SINGH

The long-playing records your dad used to listen to took more than 50 years to become popular and widely available. The magnetic audiotape you use in your car took around 40 years, and the CD-ROM took around 20 years. How much time did MP3s take to become as popular? About five to six years! Some might argue that it took more than that, but if we look at the history, work on developing the MP3 format started in 1981 and by 1991 it was standardised and ready! When did we all start blasting MP3s on old faithful Winamp? In 1997! Surprised?

What MP3s did to audio was revolutionary in more than one way. First, it made possible the transfer of CD-quality audio over low-speed mediums such as the Internet and second, it

shook the roots of the music industry, forcing it to rethink strategies on how future listeners are going to get their music. It's the easiest form of pirated music you can find today.

But then, when a rogue does something that makes the masses happy, he becomes a hero! So it is with MP3, and hundreds of electronic device companies came to support it, developing players that let you lug around your treasure trove of tunes. These players come in many different flavours, though the objective is the same.

MP3 compresses the audio data to a great extent, making it possible to store 12 times the music in the same amount of memory. This makes it possible to use solid-state Flash memory to store MP3 music that can be played back while on the move. The first generation MP3 players such as the MPMan from Saehan, were